

RATING METHODOLOGY – CEMENT

February 2026



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This rating methodology updates and supersedes ICRA's earlier methodology document on this subject, published in February 2024. While this revised version incorporates a few additional clarifications and editorial changes, ICRA's overall approach to rating cement entities remains materially similar.

Overview

The Indian cement industry is the second largest in the world, with a total installed capacity of around 660 million metric tonnes per annum (MMTPA) as on March 31, 2025, and cement production of 453 million MTPA in FY2025. The industry occupies an important place in the national economy because of its strong linkages to other sectors such as housing and infrastructure.

The cement sector exhibits high cyclicity, driven by the lumpiness in the capacity addition on the supply side. Cement production witnessed moderate growth, with 10-year CAGR of 5% during FY2016-FY2025, backed by demand from the housing and the infrastructure sectors. The industry is relatively insulated against global trends as the large freight component makes imports unviable. Thus, the competition in the Indian cement industry is largely restricted to domestic manufacturers.

Rating Methodology

This document outlines some of the key factors that are evaluated by ICRA for assessing the credit quality of a cement company. The list of rating drivers covered in this document is not exhaustive by itself, but provides an overall perspective to the lenders, investors, issuers, and other market participants on the rating considerations that are usually the most important.

For analytical convenience, the key factors are grouped under the following broad heads—Industry Risk Assessment, Business Risk Assessment, Financial Risk Assessment, Other Elements of Credit Risk Assessment, Management Quality and Assessment of Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) Risks.

Industry Risk Assessment

- Regional demand-supply scenario
- Government policies

Business Risk Assessment

- Scale
- Market position
- Operational efficiencies

Financial Risk Assessment

- Profitability
- Leverage and coverage indicators
- Adequacy of future cash flows and liquidity
- Tenure mismatches, risks relating to interest rates and refinancing
- Foreign currency-related risks

Other Elements of Credit Risk Assessment

- Debt Servicing Track Record
- Financial Flexibility
- Parentage/ Group Support
- Contingent Liabilities and Off-balance Sheet Exposures
- Event Risk

Management Quality

Assessment of Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) Risks

Industry Risk Assessment

Regional demand-supply scenario

Cement, being a bulky low-value commodity, is highly freight sensitive. The bulk of the cement produced within a region is usually consumed within the region itself, with only the excess transported to adjacent regions. Thus, price trends and capacity utilisation levels in the cement industry are determined more by regional supply-demand dynamics than by the national supply-demand balance.

On the supply side, ICRA attempts to project the likely supply position by looking at greenfield and brownfield expansion plans of manufacturers, besides low-cost supply addition through debottlenecking of the existing capacities and blending¹. Given the long gestation period for a greenfield capacity addition, the cyclicity in the sector mainly arises due to the bunching up of the capacity addition on the supply side, whereas the demand trends may not be as volatile.

The domestic cement industry, which has traditionally been fragmented, has seen some consolidation in the last decade, following several mergers and acquisitions. The industry is likely to benefit from the consolidation in terms of reduction in pricing pressures.

Government policies

The Government's direct role in the sector is limited and primarily relates to enabling access to the key raw material, limestone and key fuel, coal. The auction of limestone and coal mines is governed by the respective states, whereas royalty rates² are notified by the Central Government. Also, the Government policies relating to rural and urban housing and infrastructure development have an impact on cement demand.

Business Risk Assessment

Scale

The scale of operations for cement companies is measured in terms of sales volumes. Larger capacities result in better cost structure through greater bargaining power, access funds from the market at competitive rates, besides the economies of scale, which accrues from its size.

Market position

ICRA looks at the market share of an entity across geographies, while assessing its brand strength and market presence. The price trends and capacity utilisation levels in the cement industry are determined by regional supply-demand dynamics and the exposure to supply-demand volatility for a cement entity catering to one region would be high. ICRA takes a favourable look at manufacturers with plants in different regions, along with a strong distribution network, as the geographical diversification usually allows players to better cope with the regional demand-supply volatility.

Operational efficiencies

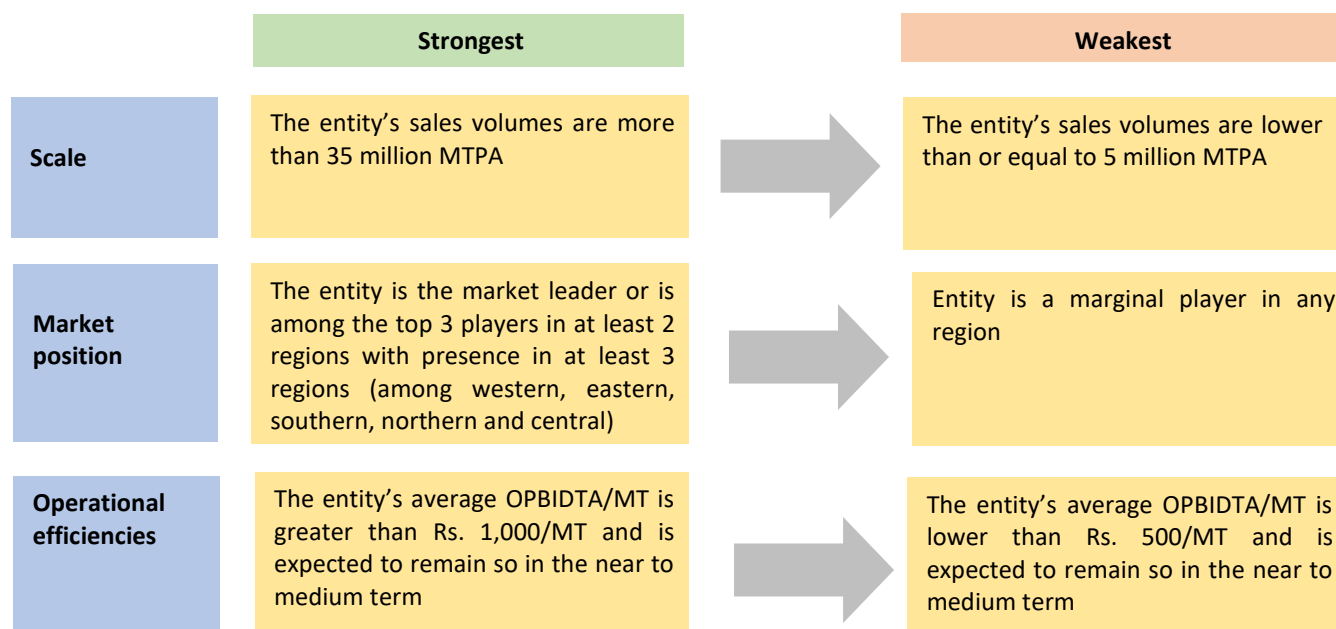
One of the key metrics to measure a cement entity's operational efficiency is 'operating profits per unit of sales volumes' or OPBIDTA/MT. The value of this parameter depends on the net cement realisation and the cost structure of an entity. Cement being a commodity item does not allow much premium pricing and thus most manufacturers are price takers in the markets they operate in. While smaller units are generally price takers, larger units have some premium, aided by branding. In such a

¹ Clinker capacity is often a constraint in the production of cement. Blended cements are a blend of portland cement and a combination of any one or more supplementary cementing materials, such as slag cement, silica fume, or fly ash.

² Paid by the cement companies to state government

scenario, control over operating expenses is essential not only to maintain cost competitiveness and maximise profitability, but also withstand cyclical downturns, and is, therefore, one of the most important rating determinants. The cost structure of a cement entity is driven by raw material costs, freight costs, power and fuel costs and blending ratio. Further, ICRA looks at the trade and non-trade sales³ mix, which impacts the profitability.

Summary of the salient business risk factors



Financial Risk Assessment

ICRA analyses the long period past financial performance trends as well as estimates the future performance trends to assess the financial risk profile of the entity. The financial metrics provide a useful reference to not only evaluate the performance trends of an entity over a given time horizon but also enable a comparison with the peers. The various financial metrics assessed by ICRA could be divided into five categories – profitability, leverage, coverage, liquidity and cash flows. This document provides a summary of why ICRA considers these ratios to be important. For a more detailed description, readers may refer to the document titled – ‘*Financial Ratio Analysis*’, published on ICRA’s website. Since the prime objective of the rating exercise is to assess the adequacy of the debt servicing capability of an entity, ICRA draws up projections on the likely financial position of the rated entity based on the expected movements in operating performance, while factoring in the capex and investment requirements as well as upcoming debt obligations. Depending on the uncertainty around how the various credit drivers could evolve in the future, ICRA carries out sensitivity analysis to assess the impact of key variables such as volumes, cement prices and EBITDA/ton on various financial metrics.

In case of groups consisting of entities with strong financial and operational linkages, various parameters such as capital structure, debt coverage indicators and future funding requirements are assessed at the consolidated/ group level.

Profitability Metrics

Profitability metrics are a measure of an entity’s efficiency and return on investments. It is imperative for most businesses to invest regularly in physical assets, product development, marketing and human capital to sustain or improve their competitive

³ Trade sales – sales to dealers and distributors who further sell it to end customers; Nontrade sales- sales directly to end customers.

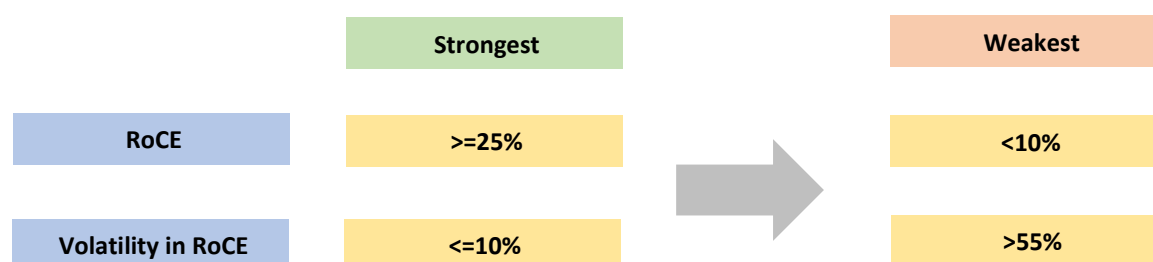
position. Entities that have superior profitability are able to do so through internal accruals with low dependence on external financing. Moreover, such entities are able to generate sufficient surplus for not only meeting their debt servicing obligations, but to reward equity investors. This improves their ability to attract fresh capital for future business requirements. Moreover, entities with higher profitability have better resilience to economic downturns and are more likely to generate adequate internal cash flows for re-investment and debt servicing.

Given the commoditised nature of cement and market participants being price-takers, the profitability of a cement manufacturer is primarily a function of its cost structure and product mix (OPC and blended). Also, since cement is a cyclical industry, the profitability of the companies in this industry varies significantly along the cycle. Nevertheless, producers having more favourable cost structures can generally be expected to better withstand the profitability pressures arising from demand-supply cycles. The key profitability metrics that ICRA evaluates include the OPBITDA margins⁴ and the PAT⁵ margins, seen in relation to changes in OPBDITA/MT of cement sold. The revenue and various cost items are analysed based on per MT of cement sold to ascertain the reasons for changes in the profitability and these parameters.

Higher OPBDITA margins are seen in relation to the RoCE⁶. While the entity may have an OPBDITA margin similar to or better than the industry average, but in case the RoCE is lower, then the reasons for the same are analysed, which could be a lower fixed asset turnover than the industry average.

Validation of Business Risk through Profitability Metrics

[Indicative Metrics⁷]



Leverage and coverage indicators

Leverage ratios measure the indebtedness of an entity. The cement industry is highly fixed capital intensive in nature and the entities that pursue an aggressive financial policy, including heavy reliance on debt financing, are likely to be more vulnerable to cyclical downturns than entities, which employ conservative financial leverage in their business. As with companies in other commodity industries exhibiting cyclical price trends, a low financial leverage is viewed as a credit positive. Low leverage ratios reflect low reliance on debt funding and imparts greater financial flexibility to raise incremental external capital (debt or equity) for re-investment in business or to tide over temporary funding shortfalls. Apart from gearing, ICRA looks at the total indebtedness ratio (ratio of all external liabilities to shareholders' funds), debt to profit ratio (ratio of borrowed funds to operating profits) and accruals to debt ratio (ratio of net cash accruals to borrowed funds) to ascertain the leverage of an entity.

⁴ Operating profit before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation

⁵ Profit after tax

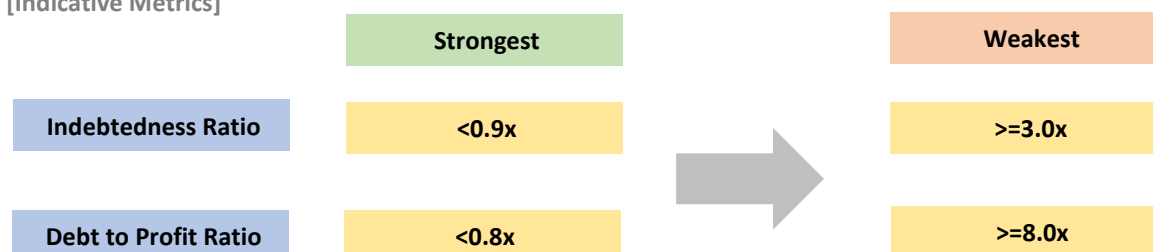
⁶ Return on capital employed

⁷ The indicative financial metrics mentioned here and elsewhere in the document are intended to provide a broad overview to the readers regarding what ICRA generally considers as 'relatively strong' or 'relatively weak' metrics. It is, however, possible that an entity has relatively weaker metrics on one or more financial parameters, but its credit risk is assessed to be low because of other mitigating factors, including (but not limited to) stronger metrics on other financial parameters, a healthy business risk profile, strong financial flexibility or a strong promoter group that is willing to extend distress support to it.

ICRA notes that the extent to which an entity leverages its balance sheet is, in addition to business requirements, also a function of the philosophy of the management towards growth and funding mix.

Assessment of Leverage

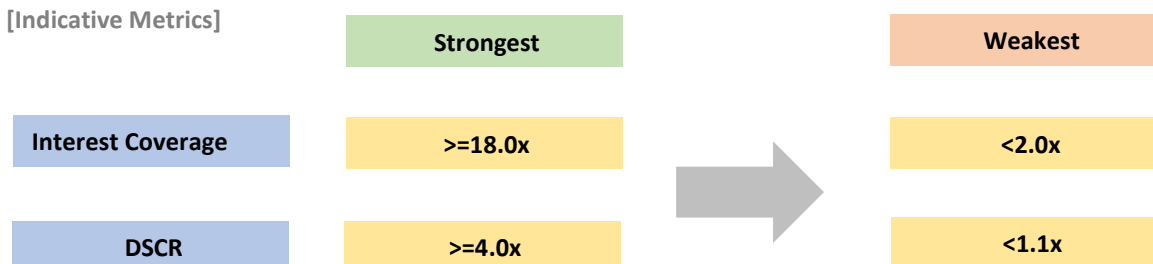
[Indicative Metrics]



Apart from the capital structure, ICRA pays attention to the coverage indicators, including interest coverage and debt service coverage, while evaluating the financial health of a cement entity. Higher the ratio, higher is the cushion available with an entity to withstand variability in profits during downcycles and thus is better from a credit evaluation perspective.

Assessment of Coverage

[Indicative Metrics]



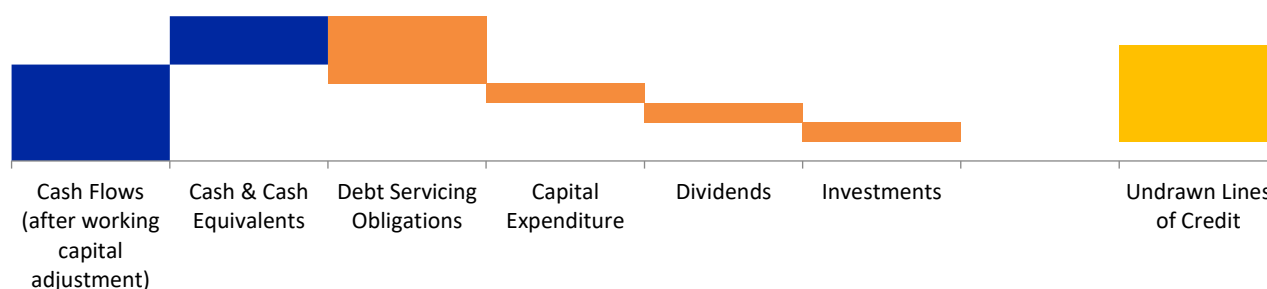
Cash flows and liquidity profile

The rating is primarily focussed on assessing the future debt servicing capabilities of a company. With the necessity for cash to service the debt obligations, it is imperative that a cash flow analysis is undertaken to evaluate the external funding requirements and likely financial position of the company, going forward. A cash flow statement represents the sources from which cash is generated, as well as its deployment. Analysed here are the trends in an entity's funds flow from operations, cash consumed to fund the working capital, the retained cash flows after paying out dividends or carrying out share buybacks, and the free cash flows after meeting debt repayment obligations and capital expenditure and investment needs.

Liquidity is the measure of an entity's ability to meet its short-term cash obligations from various internal or external resources. Internal resources include cash flows from operations, unencumbered cash and cash equivalents on balance sheet and cash inflows expected from the monetisation of physical and financial assets. External resources include undrawn lines of credit or equity capital. The short-term obligations include both the committed as well as the contingent claims on an entity's cash, including the debt servicing obligations, working capital requirements, capital expenditure and other investment outlays, dividend and share buyback-related outflows, besides the sudden demand arising from crystallisation of discrete events such as unfavourable outcome of an ongoing litigation. The higher the cushion available between the resources available (especially internal resources) and the obligations, better is the liquidity profile of an entity. Liquidity is generally assessed in conjunction with the vulnerability of an entity to timely refinancing/renewal of short-term sources of funding. Depending upon the circumstances, an entity that has a relatively modest liquidity profile, but a strong refinancing ability may not be viewed too unfavourably. ICRA notes that the liquidity available with an entity may be for a temporary period and hence an entity's overall

policy towards maintaining adequate liquidity (given the trade-off between returns and liquidity) is accorded due importance in the analytical approach⁸.

Liquidity snapshot over any defined period



Tenure mismatches and risks relating to interest rates and refinancing

Large dependence on short-term borrowings to fund long-term investments can expose an entity to significant re-financing risks, especially during periods of tight liquidity. Existence of adequate buffers of liquid assets/bank lines to meet short-term obligations is viewed positively. Similarly, the extent to which an entity could be impacted by movements in interest rates is also evaluated.

Foreign currency-related risks

For companies in the cement industry, while the revenues and costs are mostly denominated in Indian rupee. However, they can still have risks arising because of foreign currency movements where there is forex borrowing and where the entities depend on imported coal/pet coke. The entities with high dependence on imported fuel may see volatility in costs not only because of volatility in the international coal prices but also because of currency fluctuations. Additionally, the plant and machinery of the project could be funded through foreign currency loans. An unhedged foreign currency liability in the absence of corresponding foreign currency revenues may expose companies to foreign currency risk.

Other Elements of Credit Risk Assessment

Debt Servicing Track Record

The company's debt servicing track record forms an important rating consideration. Any history of past delays or defaults in meeting interest and principal repayment obligations reduces the comfort level with respect to the company's future debt servicing capability and willingness. Nevertheless, the reason behind past defaults is also analysed, which could be due to adverse demand situations in the underlying industry. The company's ability to honour its debt obligations during the period of cyclical stress is also factored in.

Parentage/ Group Support

Apart from standalone credit considerations, the likelihood of extraordinary support coming in from the parent/ Group to an entity, or the support that an entity is likely to extend to the other Group companies, is factored in while assessing the entity's credit profile. This process involves an assessment of the ability and willingness of the parent/ Group to extend support to the

⁸ For more details on how ICRA assesses liquidity, readers may refer to the document titled, "Rating Approach - Liquidity Analysis (Non-Financial Sector)" published on ICRA's website.

entity (and vice-versa), the strategic importance of the entity to the Group to which it belongs, along with the financial strength of Group entities, among others⁹.

Financial Flexibility

An entity's financial flexibility (or the lack thereof) is reflected in its ability to access capital or money markets at short notice and enjoy the confidence of banks, financial institutions and intermediaries. A strong financial flexibility allows an entity to raise fresh borrowings or refinance the existing ones in quick time, whenever required. Financial flexibility could arise from factors such as an entity's large scale of operations with strong financials, large, unencumbered cash flows, unencumbered assets and the flexibility to borrow against such assets, or strong parentage or linkages with a strong group.

In contrast, among the various measures of an entity's depleting financial flexibility, one relates to a high share of pledged promoter shareholding. A sign such as this may imply that the entity might be persuaded to distribute high dividends or support the promoter group through other means to the detriment of its own credit profile. If the promoters fail to repay their loans (availed by pledging of shares) or top up collateral when required, the lenders could sell the pledged shares. In some cases, this could trigger a change-of-control clause in the rated entity's bond indentures or loan documents and require it to redeem its debt ahead of schedule, creating a liquidity squeeze, besides affecting fresh capital raising ability. Financial flexibility could be impacted in cases of adverse industry developments, weakening business profile, or management and governance concerns, which could translate into sharp decline in market capitalisation or spike in bond yields and consequently constrain an entity's ability to raise fresh capital or materially increase its cost of capital.

Accounting Quality

The accounting policies, notes to accounts, auditors' comments and other disclosures that are a part of the annual report of a rated entity highlight the accounting quality. Deviations, if any, if highlighted by the auditor from the accounting standards/practices are assessed and the financial statements of the entity are adjusted where feasible, to reflect the impact of such deviations. Significant deviations as indicated by the statutory auditors may be indicative of weak corporate governance practices in the entity.

Contingent Liabilities and Off-balance Sheet Exposures

ICRA reviews the contingent liabilities and off-balance sheet exposures as disclosed by the entity in its Annual Report and evaluates the likelihood of their devolvement and the financial implications of the same.

Event Risk

ICRA recognises the possibility of events, such as unrelated diversification, mergers and acquisitions, business restructuring, asset sales and spin-offs, capital restructuring and litigations, which could have a material impact on the credit profile of a company. Incorporating the impact of such discrete events in the credit rating, from the beginning, is often difficult. Depending on whether and when such events occur, the rating opinion could be substantially different. To take rating decisions in such cases, ICRA applies its analytical judgment based on the rated entity's track record, the credibility of the management and the experience of having seen similar situations play out in other entities. However, given the nature of such events, it is possible that the rating may undergo a material change later, upon the occurrence of the event.

Management Quality

In addition to the business and financial risk analysis, all debt ratings incorporate an assessment of the quality of the entity's management and its financial policies.

⁹ For more details on this, readers may refer to the document titled, "Rating Approach - Implicit parent or group support", available on ICRA's website

In addition, the likely cash flow impact on the rated entity, from the possible need to support other group entities are of importance, in case the rated entity is among the stronger ones within the group. Usually, a detailed discussion is held with the management of the rated entity to understand its business objectives, plans and strategies, and views on past performance, besides the outlook on the rated entity's industry.

Some of the points assessed are:

- Experience of the promoter/ management in the industry
- Risk appetite of the promoter/ management and risk mitigation plans
- Commitment of the promoter/ management to the concerned line of business
- The rated entity's plans regarding new projects, acquisitions, and investment in non-core business segments
- The rated entity's policies on leveraging, interest risk and currency risks

Periodic interactions with the management help to estimate the possibility of the management's tendency to deviate from its core philosophy in times of stress.

Assessment of Environmental, Social and Governance Risks

The assessment of the environmental, social and governance (ESG) risks by ICRA involves a broad range of considerations that pertain to the sustainability of an entity, with focus on aspects that can have a material impact on its credit quality. While the environmental (E) & social (S) risks tend to be both sector-related as well as entity-specific and could be driven by external factors such as regulations or demographic changes, the governance (G) risks are largely entity-driven. The impact of the E&S risks on an entity's credit profile tends to be asymmetric. If the ESG risks are material but unmitigated, these generally translate into pulling down the rating, but generally the ratings are not pushed up even when the ESG context is favourable.

Environmental and Social Risks

While undertaking credit assessment of entities, ICRA seeks to incorporate all relevant credit considerations into its rating decisions while taking a forward-looking view on the risks and the mitigation. The relevant credit considerations include (sometimes overtly, sometimes covertly) the E&S factors that could affect the rated entity/ transaction.

While ICRA's analytical approach does not explicitly disaggregate these risks to assess their impact on the rating, these risks are often assessed broadly. Further, it is not always feasible to fully or precisely disaggregate the sub-components of E&S risks in credit analysis since these considerations often tend to overlap. That said, the materiality of the E&S risks and the time horizon over, which they are expected to crystallise differ widely across sectors and entities. In some cases, while the E&S risks could be material, their effect on the credit profile may be muted because of other fundamental strengths of the entity. In other cases, the adverse impact of the E&S risks is expected to play out in the future and hence these considerations do not necessarily weigh on the rating today with the expectation that by then they would possibly adapt themselves by realigning their business model.

While evaluating the E&S risks, ICRA's objective is only to assess the direct and indirect risks that an entity faces and how it already is or is intending to mitigate the impact of such risks on its credit profile. As an example, ICRA only assesses whether an entity is exposed to physical climate risks, or carbon transition risks such as those arising from changes in regulations or other environmental and social risks. ICRA seeks to understand the various mitigation and adaptation approaches that the entity is implementing to mollify these risks.

Cement manufacturing is an energy intensive process, which requires substantial use of fuel and results in greenhouse gas emissions, waste generation and pollution. The cement industry is one of the highest consumers of fuel, specifically coal as fuel to produce clinker and for power generation. Further, most of the limestone mining activities leave a negative impact on the

local ecology leading to health hazards. Increasing regulatory requirements to reduce greenhouse gas emissions, stricter air pollution standards may lead to higher costs for cement producers. The profitability and cash flow generation could face pressure if the higher compliance costs cannot be passed on to the customers.

Domestic cement companies in the recent years have been investing in alternative/renewable energy sources, replacing hitherto known sources such as fuel (in the form of coal) as well as thermal power generation, which has afforded the players multiple benefits such as better cost structure, apart from reducing carbon footprint. The usage of renewable sources of energy such as solar energy, wind energy and waste heat recovery system (WHRS) have been gaining momentum, in particular, the latter has emerged as one of the cheapest sources of power generation, given the negligible input costs. Further, the cement companies are focussing on increasing the usage of alternate fuels and improving the share of production on blended cement and consequently reduce the clinker consumption. In addition, the industry is exposed to physical climate risks, which could result in operational disruptions.

The social risks relate to the health and safety of employees involved in the mining of limestone and production of clinker and cement. The sector is exposed to labour-related risks and risks of protests/social issues with local communities, which might impact expansion/modernisation plans.

Governance Risks

A sound corporate governance structure attempts to make clear the distinction of power and responsibilities between the Board of Directors and the management. The constitution of an entity's board, besides the entity's adherence to legal and statutory compliance requirements, are factored in during credit assessments. ICRA seeks to gain a qualitative understanding of an entity's commitment to following transparent and credible practices by the way its financial statements are reported, their level of disclosures, consistency in communication and the openness about sharing information during the credit rating exercise. Besides, the corporate group structure (whether simple or complex), the rated entity's related party transactions and instances of supporting group entities at the expense of debt holders are assessed.

Summing Up

ICRA's credit ratings are a symbolic representation of its opinion on the relative credit risk associated with the instrument being rated. This opinion is arrived at following a detailed evaluation of the issuer's business and financial risks, its competitive strengths, its likely cash flows over the life of the instrument being rated and the adequacy of such cash flows vis-à-vis its debt-servicing obligations. As the note has highlighted, for a cement player, special attention is paid on the market position, an entity's scale of operation and operational efficiencies as well as management strategies for managing cyclical downturns and an overall approach towards investment and growth.

ANNEXURE

Summary of rating factors and an example to illustrate the key building blocks of a credit rating

		Strong			Comfortable			Adequate			Moderate			Weak		
Industry Risk	Industry Position															
	Scale of operations															
Business Risk	Market Position															
	Operational Efficiencies															
Financial Risk	Leverage															
	Coverage															
		Enhance					Support/ Neutral					Hinder				
	Diversification															
Do these factors enhance or hinder the credit profile?	Refinancing Dependence, Liquidity and Financial Flexibility															
	Currency Risk															
	Financial Policy															
	Management, Governance & Reporting															
		Very High				High				Moderate				Low		
Parent Support	Likelihood of Parent Support															
	Rating of Parent	AAA	AA+	AA	AA-	A+	A	A-	BBB+	BBB	BBB-	BB+	BB	BB-	B/ C category	
	Final Rating	AAA	AA+	AA	AA-	A+	A	A-	BBB+	BBB	BBB-	BB+	BB	BB-	B/ C category	

The graphic above is only for illustrative purposes and does not depict an actual rating outcome generated by a framework. The rating process typically involves the use of a framework as a reference tool to provide a broad indication of an entity's credit profile based on factors generally considered important for credit risk assessment. However, given the specific nuances and unique characteristics of individual entities, the framework may not always adequately capture all relevant considerations evaluated by the rating committee while assigning the ratings. Consequently, the ratings assigned by the rating committee may differ from the framework's indicative assessment.

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About ICRA Limited:

ICRA Limited was set up in 1991 by leading financial/investment institutions, commercial banks and financial services companies as an independent and professional investment Information and Credit Rating Agency.

Today, ICRA and its subsidiaries together form the ICRA Group of Companies (Group ICRA). ICRA is a Public Limited Company, with its shares listed on the Bombay Stock Exchange and the National Stock Exchange. The international Credit Rating Agency Moody's Investors Service is ICRA's largest shareholder.

For more information, visit www.icra.in and www.icraresearch.in

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